



Maximizing Roblox Algorithm Success for Simulator Games (2025)

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Introduction

Roblox's discovery algorithms in 2025 heavily favor games that demonstrate strong **engagement**, **retention**, and **monetization**. For simulator game developers, this means crafting experiences that not only attract clicks but also keep players coming back and investing in the game. This guide breaks down the core metrics Roblox uses to promote games, provides optimization strategies (with a focus on simulator games), and addresses common questions and advanced tactics for boosting popularity and profitability. All confirmed information is cited from official sources, and any speculative insights are clearly marked.

1. Mastering Roblox's Algorithm: Core Metrics and Optimization

Roblox internally tracks several key **"recommendation signals"** to decide which games to promote on the Home page and other discovery surfaces ¹. Each metric below is defined in its exact form (often as a 7-day average per user) and ranked in importance (1–10) for algorithmic promotion. **Confirmed** metrics come directly from Roblox's documentation, while importance rankings are **speculative** (inferred from developer discussions and official hints):

Qualified Play-Through Rate (qPTR)

- **Definition:** *Qualified play-through rate* is the number of *engaging plays* divided by the number of impressions from the Recommended sort ². In essence, qPTR measures how often users who see your game actually click **and stay long enough** to count as a meaningful play. (Roblox hasn't published the exact time threshold for an "engaging" play, but it implies that if a player joins and leaves almost immediately, that play won't qualify ³. Developers confirm that good onboarding improves qPTR by preventing quick quits ⁴.)
- **Importance: 10/10 – Confirmed critical.** This is arguably the **most important metric** for the algorithm. Roblox staff directly highlight qPTR as a key factor in recommendations ², and developers have observed that a qPTR around **0.8%–1% or higher** is needed to gain momentum on Home recommendations ⁵. A low qPTR means the game isn't converting impressions to players, so Roblox will be reluctant to keep showing it. (*Importance ranking is inferred from these behaviors – official weighting is undisclosed.*)
- **Optimization Strategies (Simulator Focus):** To boost qPTR, you need both a compelling **first impression** and a sticky **early-game experience**:
- **Eye-Catching but Accurate Icon/Thumbnail:** Use a **unique, clear icon and thumbnail** that honestly represent your simulator's gameplay ⁶. A high click-through rate (CTR) helps get players

in the door, but misleading graphics will backfire if players leave immediately. Aim for visuals that attract your target audience (e.g. bright colors, showing characters/pets, an exciting scene) **and** set correct expectations.

- **Strong Onboarding & Tutorial:** Ensure new players **don't drop out in the first minute**. Tutorials or guidance should be quick, interactive, and rewarding. For example, drop players straight into fun action (collecting coins, hatching a starter pet, etc.) rather than lengthy cutscenes. Early rewards (a free pet or tool) can hook players. *This strategy is confirmed to influence qPTR:* Roblox considers "engaging plays" as those where the player stays past the initial moment ³, so a smoother onboarding directly improves this metric.
- **Immediate Objectives:** Always give a new player a clear goal (e.g. "Collect 10 gems to upgrade your backpack"). If players understand what to do and see progress quickly, they're more likely to continue playing – turning a curious click into a qualified play.
- **Performance and Load Times:** Technical issues can tank qPTR. Optimize load time and prevent crashes/errors on all devices. Mobile players especially will abandon a game that takes too long to start.
- **Speculative Tip:** *A/B test your icons and thumbnails.* Since CTR feeds into qPTR, some developers run short ads/sponsors with different icons to see which yields higher conversion, then use the best one for organic traffic. This isn't officially documented, but it's a common growth hack to find the most effective imagery. (Mark this as speculative, as it's community practice.)

7-Day Playtime per User

- **Definition:** The total **playing time per user over the last 7 days**, capped at 60 minutes per user per day ⁷. This essentially measures how many hours, on average, each player spends in your game in a week (with a maximum of 420 minutes per user counted due to the 60min/day cap).
- **Importance: 9/10 – Confirmed high importance.** This metric reflects deep engagement. Roblox explicitly states that **average session time** and sustained play are crucial signals: experiences with high session times are more likely to be recommended ⁸. A simulator where players sink a lot of time (up to the 60 min daily cap) will be favored. *(The 9/10 rank is speculative but supported by the emphasis Roblox places on session length in discovery.)*
- **Optimization Strategies:**
 - **Engaging Core Loop:** Simulators should have an **addictive gameplay loop** that can entertain players for up to an hour in one sitting. Common tactics include progressive goals (e.g. unlocking new zones, leveling up pets, rebirth mechanics) that encourage "just one more" action. As an example, top simulators often present an endless cycle of **collect → upgrade → unlock** that naturally extends playtime.
 - **Content Pace & Variety:** Design a content pace that fills ~60 minutes per day with meaningful progress. If players can "finish" daily objectives in 10 minutes, they might log off. Instead, provide **stretch goals** that take longer (but remain fun) – e.g. a rare item that requires 45 minutes of grinding. Mini-games or events within the simulator can break up monotony and keep players online longer.
 - **Reward Longer Sessions:** Introduce session-based rewards to encourage extended play. For instance, give a **bonus reward at the 30-minute mark** or have chests that appear after an hour of play. This gives players a reason to stay until they hit those time milestones (up to the cap).
 - **Social Interaction:** Players often stay in-game longer when chatting or playing with others. Features like trading, cooperative challenges, or guilds in your simulator can organically increase session lengths as players socialize while grinding. *(This overlaps with co-play benefits, discussed later.)*

- **Note:** Roblox **limits the algorithmic benefit to 60 minutes/day** per user ⁷ ⁹ . Keeping players longer than an hour in one day won't further boost this metric. It's more valuable to encourage them to come back tomorrow than to have them AFK all day (idle time beyond 60 min won't count). So design your game to hit that sweet spot – e.g. a daily quest that takes ~50 minutes – and then entice them to return the next day for new tasks.

7-Day Play Days per User

- **Definition:** The total **unique days** a user plays your game over the last 7 days ¹⁰ . This gauges how frequently players return across a week. A value of 7 means the average user plays every day, whereas a value of 1 means most users only played on one day.
- **Importance: 9/10 – Confirmed high importance.** This is essentially a retention metric. Roblox's discovery systems prioritize games that can retain players over multiple days ¹¹ ¹² . In particular, **Day 1 retention** (the chance a new player returns the next day) is highlighted as a key driver for being featured in recommendations ¹² . High play-days-per-user indicates your game isn't just a one-session novelty – it has ongoing appeal.
- **Optimization Strategies:**
 - **Daily Login Rewards:** A proven tactic is to implement **daily rewards** (coins, spins, exclusive items) for logging in. This gives players a direct incentive to at least hop in each day, boosting this stat. Many simulator games use streak bonuses (e.g. better rewards on day 7 of consecutive play) to encourage continuous daily play.
 - **Frequent Updates & Events:** In 2025, successful simulators push updates **weekly or bi-weekly** (new content, limited-time events, etc.). Regular updates give players something new to check out, increasing the number of days they engage. For example, if you add a new egg or island on Friday, players will return that day and keep coming back over the week to explore it. Consistent content cadence trains your audience to log in often.
 - **Quests and Progression Systems:** Spread out progression requirements so players can't complete everything in one day. Daily quests or challenges that reset every 24 hours work well – e.g. "Collect 1,000 coins today for a bonus." Long-term goals (like a rare pet that requires daily tasks over a week) also ensure players have a reason to return multiple days.
 - **Community and Reminders:** Use social features to your advantage. If your simulator has clans/friends, players may log in because their friends are playing (peer pressure or to not fall behind). You can also send update notifications via Roblox's **Developer Console messaging** or social media to remind players about new content or events, prompting them to rejoin. (*Speculative:* Some devs use Discord or Twitter to announce in-game reward codes daily, effectively nudging players to log in for the code – a grey-area tactic but commonly used.)
 - **Quality Retention = Algorithm Boost:** Roblox explicitly notes that games with high Day 1 (and presumably Day 7) retention are more likely to be recommended ¹³ . This is a **confirmed** insight – so investing in features that improve player retention has a direct payoff in discovery. Make sure your early-game is compelling enough that a good percentage of new users choose to come back the next day (shoot for at least 20-30% Day 1 retention if possible). For simulators, achieving this might involve giving the player a taste of advanced gameplay (tease cool pets/zones they can get later) so they're motivated to return.

7-Day Spend Days per User

- **Definition:** The number of unique days on which a user **spends Robux** in your game over the last 7 days ¹⁴. Essentially, how many days out of a week the average user makes a purchase. This measures the consistency of monetization (not just one-off spending).
- **Importance: 7/10** – *Confirmed moderate-high importance*. Monetization is one of Roblox's core "value" signals ¹⁵. The algorithm "cares about" payer engagement: Roblox advises devs to improve **payer conversion rate** (what fraction of players spend) as part of discovery optimization ¹⁶. A game where users spend on multiple different days shows sustained investment, which likely boosts its ranking. However, monetization metrics are probably slightly secondary to pure engagement/retention – a game won't get recommended just because a few players spent a lot (it also needs good playtime and retention). (*The 7/10 ranking is speculative; exact weight is unknown.*)
- **Optimization Strategies:**
 - **Regular Microtransactions:** Incorporate purchasable items that encourage **frequent purchases** rather than a single big spend. For example, sell boost potions, game passes, or currency packs that players might want to buy repeatedly on different days. A simulator could sell a limited daily pack (e.g. "Daily VIP rewards" or a daily discounted egg) so that spenders have something to buy each session.
 - **Events & Sales:** Time-limited sales (e.g. a weekend sale on a game pass) can drive players to spend on that day. Likewise, special events might introduce exclusive items or **loot boxes** purchasable only during that event – if the event runs a week, a keen player might spend on multiple days to get what they want.
 - **Robust In-Game Shop:** Ensure your in-game store always has **something appealing at every stage** of a player's journey. Early-game bundles for new players, mid-game boosters, and late-game high-end products keep the likelihood of spending high throughout the week. Simulators often use tiered currency packs or unlocks that become relevant as the player progresses (so a user might buy a starter pack on day 1 and a different bundle on day 3 when they reach a new area, etc.).
 - **Encourage Repeat Purchases:** Design some purchases to be consumable or beneficial repeatedly. For instance, a *1.5x coin boost for 20 minutes* can be bought multiple times, and a dedicated player might buy it on several different play sessions. Another example: if your game has a donation or tipping mechanic for rewards (some simulators let players spend Robux for server-wide bonuses), a small group of users might spend a bit every day to help the community (and flex their support).
 - **Track Monetization Metrics:** Use Roblox analytics to watch your **payer conversion** and revenue per user. If you notice players tend to only spend on one day (e.g. the day they start), introduce ways to monetize later. The algorithm favors games with strong monetization **benchmarks comparable to similar games** ¹⁶, so consider studying how top simulator games monetize across time (many share common strategies like pay-to-progress faster, exclusive cosmetic pets, etc.).
 - **Warning:** Do **not** sacrifice gameplay quality for monetization. If players feel a simulator is too pay-to-win or a cash grab, retention will drop – hurting the very metrics the algorithm values more. Always balance monetization with fun; a smaller percentage of happy spenders on multiple days is better than a large initial spend that drives others away.

7-Day Robux Spent per User

- **Definition:** The total **Robux amount spent per user** in your game over the last 7 days ¹⁷. This is essentially the average revenue per user (ARPU) your game earns in a week (across all users, including non-spenders).

- **Importance: 7/10** – *Confirmed moderate-high importance.* This metric ties into monetization as well, indicating the **monetary value** players derive from your game. Roblox's guidance to creators mentions improving **ARPPU (Average Revenue Per Paying User)** and overall revenue per user for better discovery results ¹⁶ . A higher 7-day Robux per user means on average your users are contributing more Robux, which signals a profitable and engaging experience. Like spend days, this likely carries weight but won't save a game with poor retention (e.g. a game with few but very rich players might not sustain algorithm exposure if most other players leave). *(7/10 is speculative; exact weighting unknown.)*
- **Optimization Strategies:**
- **Offer High-Value Purchases:** To raise the average spent, include some **premium priced items** for the whales (players willing to spend a lot). Game passes or bundles in the range of 500–1000 Robux, exclusive limited pets for high prices, or bulk currency packs can significantly boost the per-user spend when purchased. Not everyone will buy them, but those who do lift the average. (Many simulators offer a range of passes from cheap (<100 Robux) to very expensive (>1000 Robux) to cover all spending appetites.)
- **Multiple Monetization Channels:** Diversify how players can spend Robux: game passes (permanent upgrades), developer products (one-time purchases like coins or boosts), and subscription-like features (e.g. a VIP pass that gives benefits over time). A player might buy several different things over a week. For example, in a pet simulator a user could buy an XP boost on day 1, a extra pet slot gamepass on day 3, and a bundle of gems on day 5 – together increasing that user's 7-day spend.
- **Value Updates:** Each content update is an opportunity to introduce new things to buy (new eggs, tools, or features that can be sped up with Robux). Highlight these in-game with a UI prompt ("New Limited Egg available!") so players notice and consider spending. Frequent spenders will often purchase new offerings, raising their weekly total.
- **Measure and Adjust:** Use the Creator Dashboard's monetization stats to see your **Revenue Per User**. If it's low, identify where players lose interest in spending. Perhaps your pricing is too high (scaring off moderate spenders) or too low (not enough high-end options). Top-earning games optimize prices over time – sometimes lowering prices to increase volume, or raising on premium items to maximize from dedicated fans.
- **Community Feedback:** Pay attention to player feedback on your monetization. Happy players will spend more over time. If your simulator's community complains about feeling forced to spend, consider adding ways to grind for premium currency as a gesture – paradoxically, being generous can improve goodwill and long-term spending. The goal is to create an environment where spending Robux feels rewarding, not compulsory.
- **Confirmed Insight:** Roblox equates higher monetization with user "investment" and long-term interest ¹⁸ ¹⁹ . If a user spends Robux, they likely value the experience and will stick around (improving other metrics too). So increasing this metric can amplify others like playtime and play days, creating a virtuous cycle of algorithm-friendly stats.

7-Day Intentional Co-Play Days per User

- **Definition:** The frequency of users **playing together with friends** (intentionally) in your game over the last 7 days ²⁰ . "Intentional co-play" means a user is joining a friend or inviting a friend to play, or using a private server together – as opposed to just random matchmaking. Essentially, how often are players experiencing your game in a social/friend context each week.
- **Importance: 6/10** – *Confirmed moderate importance.* This is a newer signal Roblox added to identify games that foster social play. It **"strongly indicates user interest,"** according to Roblox's discovery team ²¹ . While perhaps not as heavy as core engagement metrics, a high co-play metric can give

your game an edge, since Roblox wants to promote experiences that people enjoy with friends (as those tend to retain users better long-term). *(The 6/10 ranking is speculative; Roblox hasn't publicized weightings, but the fact they highlight this signal means it does matter.)*

- **Optimization Strategies:**

- **Friend Invite Features:** Make it easy and tempting for players to invite friends. Roblox provides an in-game invite prompt API – use it at opportune moments (e.g. after a player completes a tutorial or achieves something cool, prompt “Invite a friend to show off your new ____!”). If two or more friends actively join each other, it will count toward co-play days ²⁰.
- **Design for Cooperative Play:** While many simulators are inherently single-player grinds, consider adding **cooperative elements**. For instance, a *boss event* that is easier with friends, or areas that give bonus rewards when players are near friends. Even simple mechanics like trading or comparing collections can encourage players to pull in their buddies (“I’ll join your server to trade you this rare pet”).
- **Private Servers & Social Hubs:** If appropriate, enable free private servers for your game, so friend groups can easily play together. You can also create social hub places (like a town square) if your simulator’s gameplay is mostly solo – just having a hangout spot can boost social interactions.
- **In-Game Incentives for Groups:** Reward players for co-playing. For example, some simulators give a **coin XP boost when in a server with Roblox friends** or spawn special resources if many friends are together. These incentives directly drive the metric up by making co-play beneficial. *(This tactic is confirmed as effective – Roblox’s guidance suggests that designing gameplay to “motivate users to spend time together” will increase intentional co-play and thus retention ²².)*
- **Community Challenges:** Run events that require collective effort, like a server-wide goal (“All players collectively mine 1 million rocks to spawn a mega treasure”). Players might invite friends to help reach the goal. This not only improves co-play stats but also general engagement.
- **Speculative Note:** Games strong in social play might compensate for slightly lower solo engagement. Roblox staff have mentioned that different play patterns can succeed – e.g. “*medium session times but tons of co-play sessions*” can be just as viable as long sessions alone ²³. So, a simulator that isn’t the deepest game ever could still do well if it becomes a social hangout. Cultivate a community aspect (perhaps via a Roblox group or Discord) to encourage this.

Confirmed vs. Speculative: The six metrics above (qPTR, 7-day playtime, play days, spend days, Robux spent, co-play days) are **confirmed** by Roblox as core signals in the recommendation algorithm ²⁴. The algorithm looks at all of them in combination – you don’t need to “max out” every stat, but improving as many as possible will yield better discovery ¹¹. The 1–10 importance rankings are **speculative** and provided for guidance; Roblox has not released exact weights. However, developer consensus and Roblox’s own tips suggest **engagement and retention (qPTR, playtime, play days)** weigh slightly more than pure monetization. Always prioritize making a genuinely fun, high-quality game – focusing solely on metrics can backfire. As Roblox staff put it: “*it’s most effective to focus on creating a high-quality, engaging experience. Prioritize core gameplay, user retention, and accurate metadata to improve overall user experience.*” ²⁵ High metrics will naturally follow a great game.

2. Additional Considerations

Beyond the core stats, Roblox developers frequently ask nuanced questions about how certain practices or behaviors affect discovery. Below are concise answers to these specific topics, backed by current knowledge as of 2025:

Does CTR affect algorithm exposure, or just performance per spot?

CTR (Click-Through Rate) – the ratio of clicks to impressions – is important, but the **algorithm doesn't use raw CTR alone as a global factor**. Instead, Roblox uses *Qualified Play-Through Rate (qPTR)* as the key metric, which already incorporates a form of CTR (only counting clicks that lead to engaged plays) ². In practical terms, a higher CTR on your game's icon will help you get more players *only if those players stick around*. A low CTR can hurt you by limiting initial plays, but a high CTR with poor retention won't fool the algorithm for long (such players won't count as "qualified" and your qPTR will drop). **In summary:** CTR mostly matters at the impression level – it determines if a particular user clicks your game when shown. It's great to have an attractive icon (high CTR) **but** Roblox's discovery system primarily optimizes for engaged play conversions (qPTR) and retention ²⁶ ². So, think of CTR as the first step of qPTR. Improve your CTR by polishing icons/thumbnails and targeting the right audience, but remember it's not a magic bullet by itself. (This is confirmed by Roblox's focus on qPTR; any direct impact of CTR beyond that is speculative. Developers generally agree it's *necessary but not sufficient* for algorithm success.)

Does keeping AFK/idle players benefit algorithm metrics, or are they filtered out?

Having players remain **AFK (away from keyboard)** in your game can inflate your concurrent player count and session times, but Roblox **does impose limits and focuses on real engagement**. Notably, the algorithm caps counted playtime at **60 minutes per user per day** ⁷. This means if a player idles for hours, only the first 60 minutes contribute to your 7-day playtime metrics. After that, there's no added algorithmic benefit. Roblox does *not* explicitly "filter out" idle players from metrics as long as they're in-game (time is time), but extremely brief visits are discounted via qPTR and retention measures. If a player is idling, they are actually boosting your **playtime** and possibly **play days** (if they at least join each day) up to the cap. However, idle players likely won't contribute to monetization or long-term retention (and could even hurt your ratios if they eventually leave and never return). **Bottom line:** Keeping players online with idle incentives can slightly pad your engagement metrics (confirmed by premium payout systems counting AFK time ²⁷), but there are diminishing returns. The most valuable metrics (qPTR, day-1 retention) assume active engagement. If Roblox detects a game that's purely an "AFK simulator" with no real gameplay, it might classify it as low-quality content (especially after the late-2024 crackdown on low-quality, misleading games ²⁸). So while a bit of idle time (e.g. leaving the game on to grind resources) won't harm and does count toward the 60-minute daily cap, you shouldn't rely on AFK farming as a primary strategy. Focus on interactive engagement – *that* is what truly drives the algorithm.

Does session hopping affect average session time and visibility?

Session hopping – where players leave and rejoin (or jump between servers) frequently – will reduce your game's *average session length* (since sessions are broken up into shorter chunks). A lower average session time can be a negative signal, as Roblox watches session duration as an indicator of enjoyment ⁸. However, what really matters is the **total playtime and retention** of the user, not whether it was one continuous session or multiple. If a player hops but in total plays 30 minutes, it contributes the same 30 minutes to your 7-day playtime per user. That said, lots of hopping could imply something is frustrating users (e.g. they are server-hopping to find content or leaving due to crashes), which might correlate with them eventually quitting sooner. From an algorithm perspective, occasional rejoining isn't penalized explicitly, but *frequent short sessions could hurt your average session metric and qPTR*. For example, if many users join and leave after 2 minutes (perhaps to exploit rejoining for rewards or because they are unsatisfied), those initial sessions might not count as "qualified plays" ³, lowering qPTR. **In summary:**

One continuous long session is generally better than multiple stop-start sessions of the same total length, at least for the *average session time* stat (which Roblox does care about ⁸). To maximize visibility, design your simulator so players aren't compelled to constantly rejoin. If your game loop requires server hopping (some simulators have players hop servers to find rare items or events), consider adding in-game features to reduce this (e.g. server-wide announcements of events, or a server matchmaking system). Keeping players engaged in one session will bolster your average session time, which the algorithm treats as a quality signal. This is inferred from how session metrics influence recommendations ⁸; Roblox hasn't stated a direct penalty for hopping, but it's best to minimize any behavior that fragments play sessions.

Should developers regularly change their game icons to optimize CTR, or stick with one great design?

There's no one-size-fits-all answer here – it depends on whether your current icon is performing well. **If you have a high-CTR, recognizable icon** that effectively represents your brand, you shouldn't change it for no reason. Consistency builds brand recognition; players can quickly spot your game in a list if your icon is iconic (pun intended). However, **updating your icon periodically** can be beneficial in certain cases:

- **When CTR is low or stagnating:** If data (from ads or Roblox metrics) shows your icon isn't enticing clicks (say your CTR is below ~1% on sponsor ads, which is low ²⁹), experimenting with a new icon design or style could improve it. Many developers iterate on icons until they find a hit.

- **Highlighting New Content or Events:** Simulator games often have major updates (new worlds, holidays events, etc.). Changing your icon to reflect the latest update (e.g. a Christmas-themed icon during December, or adding a new pet character to the icon) can attract lapsed players' attention and signal "this game has new stuff." This can bump your CTR among existing followers and even new users. Top simulator games do this frequently – for example, a well-known pet simulator updates its icon almost every week to showcase the newest feature or mascot (anecdotal but common practice).

- **A/B Testing Variations:** In the early stage of a game, you might rotate through a few icon variants to see which one sticks. Once you identify a "great design," though, stick with it except for the above reasons. Continuously changing a good icon without purpose can confuse players or dilute your branding.

Roblox does *not* give an algorithm boost just for changing your icon itself. Any benefit comes from improved player engagement (CTR or re-engagement) due to the new icon. The **Creator Hub documentation** emphasizes that both thumbnails and icons should be high-quality and representative ³⁰ – it doesn't say you need to keep them static or change them regularly, just that they should be effective. **Recommendation:** Keep an eye on your icon's performance. If you suspect "icon fatigue" or see a drop in CTR, try a refresh. Otherwise, leverage your icon as a stable brand asset, and use thumbnails/videos to provide variety. A single great design can serve you long-term, with occasional updates during special events for a spike in interest. *(This advice is based on marketing best-practices and developer experiences – there's no official rule on icon change frequency.)*

Can a previously popular game be revived effectively, or does algorithm history / user memory limit this?

Reviving a once-popular game **is possible**, but it can be challenging. The Roblox algorithm does not permanently "blacklist" a game for losing popularity – if you improve the game's metrics again, the algorithm will respond. However, you're fighting two things: **the algorithm's momentum and player perception**. If your game was popular and then its metrics declined (players stopped returning, etc.), the algorithm likely reduced its exposure over time. To get back in, you'll need to dramatically boost those core

stats (retention, engagement) again so the system takes notice. This often requires a **major update or overhaul** that essentially makes your game fresh again. Developers have done this by adding massive new features, overhauling graphics, or fixing fundamental flaws and then treating it like a “relaunch.”

That said, **user memory** is a factor: players who tried your game during its decline may have formed a negative opinion. Roblox’s personalized recommendations might even avoid showing the game to users who quit it previously (the platform does consider individual user’s past interactions). So a revival may involve finding a **new audience or rebranding** to overcome preconceptions. For example, if *Super Simulator* was big in 2023 but then died, bringing it back in 2025 might entail renaming it or marketing it such that players see it as “*Super Simulator – Reborn Update*” to signal things have changed. Some developers opt to create a **sequel or a new place** (see next question) for a fresh start, especially if the original game’s ratings (likes/dislikes) or retention stats are holding it down.

In practice, we have seen games make comebacks with enough effort: e.g. a classic tycoon game regained players after a massive content update years later (through press coverage and featuring). However, many games struggle to fully recapture their peak unless the revamp is extraordinary. **Conclusion:** The algorithm doesn’t permanently punish an old game (there’s no hard evidence of an algorithmic “memory” beyond your current metrics). A previously popular game **can** be revived if you significantly improve it and possibly re-market it. Just be aware you may need to invest in advertising or community outreach to jump-start the new wave of traffic. If the core issue was the game itself, fix that first. Once your retention and engagement are back to competitive levels, Roblox will start recommending it more (the slate can be wiped clean metrics-wise after a strong update). This is partly speculative – Roblox hasn’t detailed how past performance weighs in – but developers commonly either revive via big updates or launch anew. Both paths can work, but a successful revival demands almost treating the game like a new release to overcome any stigma.

Are icons being phased out in favor of thumbnails across discovery surfaces?

Yes – Roblox is shifting toward larger thumbnail images in many discovery contexts, though icons still play a role. In 2024–2025, Roblox introduced **16:9 aspect ratio thumbnails** on the Home page’s recommendation carousels, replacing the traditional square icons in that specific section ³¹. As of early April 2025, the Home “Recommended For You” section uses big 16:9 image tiles for experiences (which are usually the first thumbnail in your game’s media) instead of the small icon ³¹. This change has rolled out on mobile, tablet, and desktop for both new and existing users ³² ³¹. The reason is to create a more immersive, informative look – Roblox found it increased engagement with recommendations (a 7.2% increase in unique plays during tests) ³³.

However, **icons are not gone entirely**. The square icon is still used in certain places: for example, the **Continue Playing** section on Home (showing games you’ve played) still shows smaller tiles – Roblox noted that familiar experiences perform fine with smaller icons ³⁴. Also, in the **Discover page and Search results**, at the time of writing, you will often see the game’s icon (or a smaller thumbnail) depending on the layout. Icons also remain the image that shows on your game’s detail page as the small icon next to the title, and they’re used for your experience’s branding in the Developer Console, etc. Essentially, thumbnails are taking over **promotional slots** to give players a richer preview, but the **game icon is still your logo/brand**. In fact, Roblox’s own documentation states: “*thumbnails help users know what your experience offers, [but] icons are still important to help users recognize your experience and grow its brand.*” ³⁰.

For developers, this means you should ensure you have high-quality **16:9 thumbnails** ready – especially the first thumbnail, since that’s what will show on Home. Thumbnail Personalization (a feature Roblox offers to show different thumbnails to different player segments) can be leveraged to attract the right audience ³⁵. But don’t neglect your icon: it’s the foundation of your game’s identity and will be seen in contexts where space is limited or a quick identifier is needed. In summary, Roblox is indeed prioritizing thumbnails on discovery surfaces to improve user engagement, but icons remain in use for recognition. Optimize both: use thumbnails to visually communicate gameplay (treat them like mini movie posters or screenshots of exciting moments), and maintain a distinct icon for brand consistency. This trend is confirmed by Roblox’s announcements ³¹, so expect thumbnails to be crucial in discovery going forward.

Does Roblox suppress duplicate/copied versions of games, or can developers relaunch to reset stats and wipe history?

Roblox does not have an outright algorithm rule that says “if two games are identical, suppress one” – but there are a few things to consider:

- **Copied Games by Different Developers:** If someone copies another game’s assets and uploads it, Roblox’s discovery may initially treat it like any other new game. There isn’t an automatic suppression purely for being a duplicate. However, such copies usually perform poorly in retention (players realize it’s a knock-off or there’s no ongoing support) and often get reported. Roblox can moderate blatant asset theft or trademark infringement. So while a clone might appear briefly, it rarely sustains traction (either due to moderation or players favoring the original). The algorithm might indirectly “suppress” low-quality copies simply because their engagement metrics are worse than the original’s. Popular games also often have a fanbase that will downvote obvious copies, affecting the copy’s ratings.
- **Re-launching Your Own Game:** It is **possible and sometimes effective** for a developer to create a new experience entry (a place with a new game ID) that is essentially a relaunch of an older game. This “resets” all discovery metrics – you start fresh with no play history, like/dislike ratio, or retention data. The advantage is you get a clean slate in the eyes of the algorithm and players: any past poor metrics or reputation of the old game won’t carry over. Many devs do this when a game didn’t initially succeed – they overhaul it and re-publish as a new experience rather than updating the old one. Roblox does not punish you for doing this; in fact, some genres (like simulators) commonly iterate through sequels or new versions (e.g., “Simulator 2”, “X Simulator Reborn”, etc.) to capture the “new game” hype. The new game can potentially climb the discovery ranks if its metrics are good, without fighting the baggage of the old stats.
- **Are duplicates detected by the algorithm?** As of 2025, there’s no known algorithmic fingerprinting that links a new game to a previous version by the same developer. The algorithm looks at player behavior – if players of your old game also try the new one and like it, that’s actually a good thing (you retained your audience through a new title). If you literally create two copies and both are live, you’re splitting your player base and data, which isn’t wise. It’s better to focus on one. But if the question is “can I upload my game again to wipe the slate clean?” – the answer is **yes, you can**, and some developers have done so to escape bad ratings or a slump. Just be aware you lose any accumulated social proof (like counts, favorites, followers) on the old game, and you’ll have to redirect your community to the new place.

- **Roblox's stance:** There's no official statement against re-launching or cloning your own game. The platform's interest is in surfacing games that players enjoy (measured by engagement/retention). If your re-launched game achieves that, it will get exposure. If it's the same issues as before, it won't. They *do* discourage low-effort spam (like uploading many barely-different copies to game the system), which could fall under guideline violations if done excessively, but a genuine relaunch or sequel is an accepted practice.

Conclusion: Roblox doesn't algorithmically suppress duplicates in a manual way, but poor copies tend to fail on their merits. If you want to reset your game's standing, a well-executed relaunch can work. This effectively "wipes history" in terms of discovery data. Just ensure that the new version is significantly improved – otherwise, you'll just recreate the negative stats. And communicate with your existing player base (via the old game's shout or social media) so your fans know to move to the new game. This strategy is somewhat **grey-area** but commonly used; just avoid anything that looks like network spamming (don't run multiple identical games to siphon players – focus on making one revived game successful).

3. Exploiting Grey Areas & Expert-Level Strategies

(Disclaimer: The following techniques are not officially endorsed and some tread the line of what's acceptable. Use them at your own risk – they may provide short-term boosts, but abusing loopholes can backfire if players catch on or Roblox adjusts the algorithm. These insights come from developer community experiences.)

Even with a solid game and adherence to best practices, some developers look for extra edges to boost algorithm exposure and profitability. Here are a few **grey-area and expert strategies** that simulator devs have used or discussed, along with commentary on their effectiveness:

- **"Soft Launch" with Alts or Friends:** One trick is to initially populate your game with a small group of players (often friends, testers, or alt accounts) to seed decent metrics before the wider public arrives. For example, having 10–20 players actively playing at launch can generate a baseline of qPTR, session time, etc., that isn't zero. If those players are coached to play for a while (and maybe spend a bit of Robux), your game might start off with above-average stats for its size. This can help it appear in "Up and Coming" or get a few recommendation impressions to real users. **Grey factor:** Using alt accounts purely to inflate numbers is against spirit (and farming Robux to yourself via alts is against TOS), but having friends play and give genuine feedback is fair game. This strategy basically **warms up your metrics**. Just ensure that when real players come, the game holds up, or the metrics will crash anyway.
- **Cross-Promotion and Network Effects:** If you have multiple games or know fellow developers, you can cross-promote to share traffic. For instance, put a **portal or GUI button in your successful simulator that links to your new game**. This can drive a surge of engaged users to the new project – since they liked your old game, they're likely to give the new one a solid try (boosting qPTR). Some dev teams create a whole network of games that feed into each other. This is an expert strategy to **leverage existing player bases**. It's not forbidden; Roblox even allows teleporting players between experiences. Just be careful not to annoy players with too many ads for other games. Done tactfully (like a small "Try our new game!" panel or an event that connects two games), this can kickstart a new game's discovery by giving it quality traffic from day one.

- **Event Collaborations:** Partner with other popular games for crossover events. For example, your simulator could have a special item themed after another game, and that game offers a reward for checking out your simulator. This kind of collab can funnel players into your experience who might not have come otherwise. It's a win-win: both games share communities. We've seen this with simulators and tycoons doing collab events. It's an advanced marketing move that requires networking with other devs, but it can expose your game to tens of thousands of new users in a very organic way (players come because they're curious about the collab, not because of an ad). This can drastically boost your metrics during the event and potentially leave you with a larger player base after.
- **Leveraging Roblox Premium Payouts (EBP):** If your goal is profitability and your game attracts a lot of Roblox Premium subscribers, note that Roblox pays developers based on Premium playtime. Some "AFK games" exploited this by literally being designed for Premium users to idle. **Grey area:** Creating content primarily to farm Premium payouts (e.g. an idle zone that encourages Premium users to stay logged in) can make you some Robux, but Roblox monitors engagement quality. If it's clear a game is only about AFK time with no gameplay, it might not get recommended or could be removed from discovery for low quality. A more legitimate expert approach is: *if you have a high percentage of Premium players, cater to them*. Premium users tend to spend more time (since they're getting payout credit and often are older players). So you might add Premium-only perks or areas in your simulator to attract and retain those users, thereby increasing the overall time and payout you get. It's not an algorithm boost per se, but it directly increases your revenue and even indirectly your metrics (Premium players staying longer boosts playtime stats). Some top games generate millions of Robux from these payouts alone.
- **Tuning the Algorithm via Analytics:** Expert developers constantly watch the **Creator Analytics Dashboard** (and third-party tools like RoMonitor stats) to gauge the impact of changes. They might observe, for example, that changing the tutorial improved Day 1 retention from 20% to 30%, or that a new feature dropped average session time by 2 minutes (bad sign!). By actively monitoring these metrics (the same ones the algorithm looks at) ² ³⁶, they iterate quickly. This isn't a "loophole" but an advanced practice: treat your game updates like scientific experiments. When you know how each tweak affects qPTR or retention, you can fine-tune the experience to be as algorithm-friendly as possible. Roblox's addition of the Home Recommendations analytics in 2025 ³⁷ is a boon here – use those graphs to spot trends (e.g. if impressions dipped, was it after an update? Did your qPTR drop due to a bug?). The grey area might be if someone tries to artificially manipulate these stats (like kicking players who are idle to inflate "engaged" percentage – not recommended because it might annoy users). But overall, **data-driven iteration** is an expert strategy that legitimately improves your game and metrics hand in hand.
- **Psychological Pricing and FOMO:** To maximize profits, savvy devs employ pricing psychology. "Limited time" store items, rotating stock, and **fear-of-missing-out (FOMO)** tactics can urge players to spend more, which raises your monetization metrics. For example, selling an exclusive pet for 1,000 Robux that will go off sale in 3 days creates urgency. Players who can afford it might splurge now rather than later. Also, having a range of price points (including very high-end options) means your biggest fans can drop large sums (helping that 7-day Robux per user stat). A grey aspect is if you **manufacture urgency too often** or use misleading timers (countdowns that reset – not ethical and will anger players). Stick to genuine limited content or seasonal exclusives. The goal is to spur engagement and spending in bursts (which can spike your game up the Popular sort due to revenue

or player count surges). Many simulator devs plan content drops with this in mind: big updates on weekends with some items that are only obtainable (or cheaper) for that weekend. This strategy can yield a sharp increase in CCU and monetization, which then feeds the algorithm to show your game as “trending.” Just be prepared to deliver on the hype, or players will churn afterward.

- **Exploiting Time Zones & Regions:** One lesser-known trick is timing your game’s activity to appear on sorts like “*Top Rated*” or “*Up and Coming*” in certain regions. Roblox’s discovery can sometimes be region-specific. For example, a game that becomes popular in one country might get featured to those users more. Some developers, in the past, would launch or sponsor in a smaller region to climb the charts there, hoping it spills over globally. Another example is scheduling updates during peak usage times (Friday afternoon U.S. time) so that you maximize the immediate influx of players (improving your chances of hitting the front page while many users are online to see it). These are softer tactics – their effectiveness can vary now that the algorithm is highly personalized. But it costs nothing to be smart about timing (don’t update at 3 AM if your core audience is asleep; you’ll waste the initial momentum).
- **Community Building & Hype:** Lastly, an expert strategy that isn’t algorithm manipulation per se but greatly affects your success: build a **community around your game**. Active communities (Discord servers, Roblox groups, Twitter followings) can be mobilized to test updates, share the game, and create buzz. For simulators, engaging the community with teasers of upcoming content keeps them excited (they’ll come back for the update – boosting those play days). A hyped update can even push players to bring their friends (affecting that co-play metric). Some developers even use **content creators** (YouTubers/Twitch streamers) to spike interest – a popular YouTuber making a video on your simulator can flood in thousands of players, which the algorithm will notice as a surge in engagement. The grey area here might be *paying* influencers or using alt accounts to artificially inflate community size, but generally this is all above board. The key point: a passionate player base is like an engine that will propel your metrics naturally. Nurture it with frequent communication and rewards (e.g. in-game codes for your followers), and they’ll help your game stay successful.

In conclusion, while there are certainly “tricks” to amplify your game’s visibility and revenue, **nothing replaces a genuinely enjoyable game**. Grey-area tactics can give you a momentary boost, but the Roblox algorithm in 2025 is very adept at reading actual player satisfaction over time ³⁸ ³⁹ . Use these expert strategies to complement your game design, not to compensate for its shortcomings. The most “exploitative” thing you can do is simply **understand what the algorithm wants (engagement, retention, monetization)** and deliver that by making a game players love to play (and maybe a bit of clever marketing on the side). Good luck, and may your simulator climb the charts in both popularity and profits!

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(All information is up-to-date as of April 2025. Speculative points are derived from developer experiences and are indicated as such. Remember that Roblox may continue to update its algorithm, so staying informed through official channels and the dev community is crucial.)

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